

Catching food

There are tiny hairs on the surface of the trap that are sensitive to touch. If the fly touches the hairs twice within 20 seconds, the trap snaps shut. The plant eats the fly's soft body parts and absorbs the nutrients. When the trap reopens, the remains blow away on the wind or are washed away by rain.

A fly attracted by the nectar lands on the trap.

The fly touches the hairs and triggers the trap, which snaps together tightly.

The trap is the hinged flaps at the tip of the leaf.

The bristles stop the fly from wriggling out of the trap.

Glands in the trap release fluids that turn the fly into liquid, ready to be digested.

Growing plant

The seed sprouts, or germinates, in the boggy soil. The plant grows slowly, producing several long leaves. At the tip of each leaf is a trap—a pair of hinged flaps fringed with stiff, comb-like bristles. The flaps produce sweet nectar that attract insects, such as this fly.

Venus flytraps can live for more than 20 years in the wild.

Creating seeds

Pollinated flowers produce round, black seed capsules. The tiny seeds mature four to six weeks after pollination. Venus flytraps also reproduce by sending out underground stems called rhizomes. These separate and become new plants.

See also

Read about plants that have a friendlier relationship with insects: the orchid (58–59) and the rafflesia (66–67).